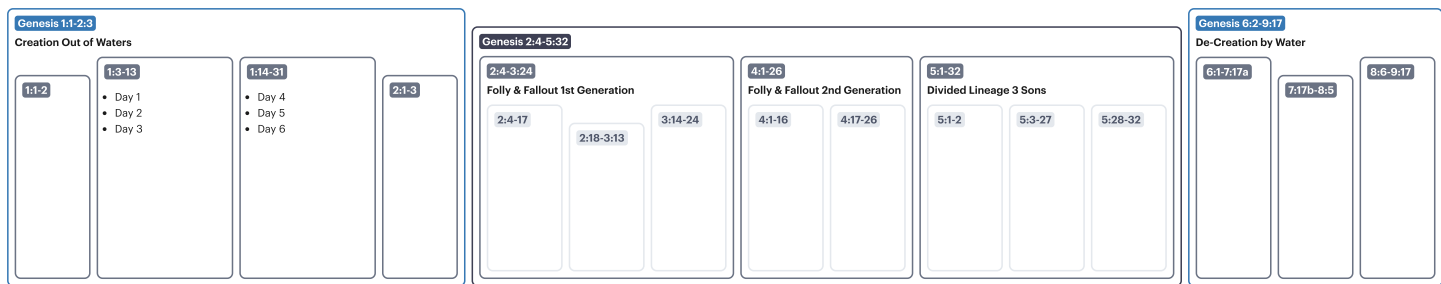


Session 2: The Thematic Melody of the Hebrew Bible

Key Takeaways

- Like a symphony, the Hebrew Bible introduces readers to a pattern of key themes in its opening chapters, setting a template for the rest of the collection.
- The biblical authors structure Yoseph’s story around the pattern of themes from Genesis 1-11 by repeating the sequence of events and by repeating key vocabulary to signal this connection.

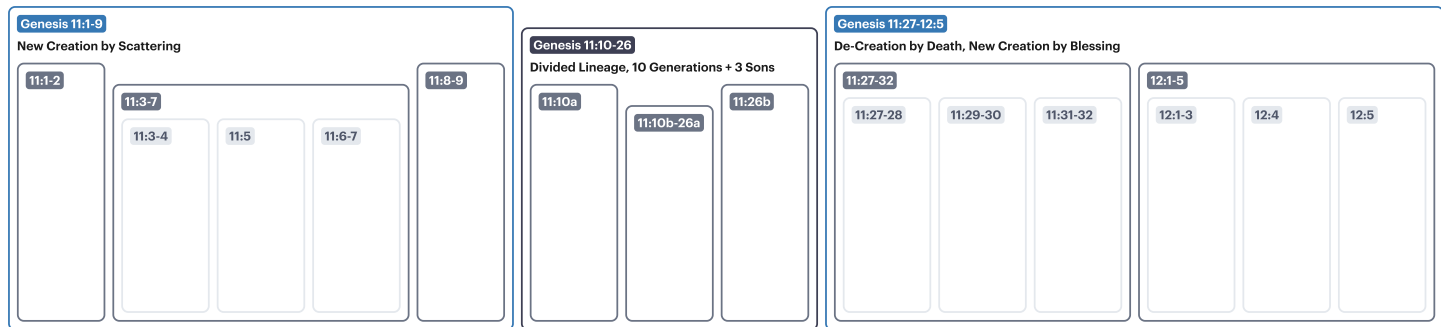
The Literary Design of Genesis and the Thematic Melody of the Hebrew Bible



Genesis 1:1-9:17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).



Genesis 6:1-11:9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).



Genesis 11:1-12:5. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

These thematic cycles set up a narrative pattern, a thematic melody, that re-cycles with each generation, developing and advancing the melody. The basic melody goes like this.

1. Creation and blessing

- God brings order/life/blessing out of chaos/waters/death/curse.
- Key words
 - Life, blessing, create, establish, seed, sprout, grow, fruit, fruitful, multiply
 - Seven, fullness, oath (all spelled שבע)
- Key images: dry land, refuge, safety, order

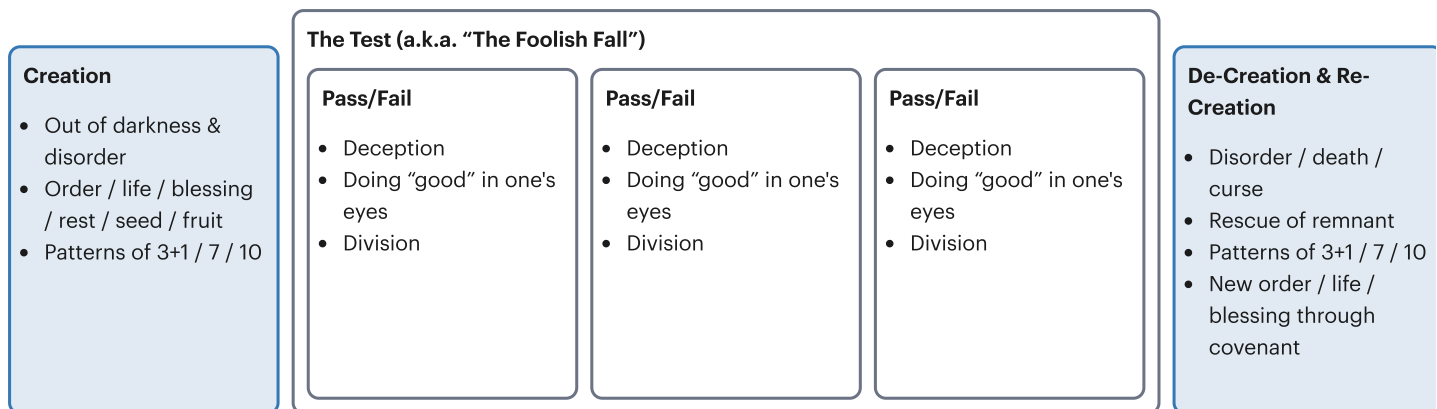
2. Folly, test, and failure (a.k.a. “the foolish fall”)

- God invites a chosen human partner to share in the order/life/blessing, which places a decision/test of their trustworthiness on the table.
- God’s chosen partner fails/succeeds the test, usually involving deception/division/violence.
- The same person/next generation faces their own opportunity and test and fails/succeeds, usually involving an intensified expression of deception/division/violence.
- The escalating sequence of tests and failures leads to a separation between the key characters so that one person or family splits off from the rest and is chosen by God for a new future.
- Key words found in Genesis 2-3, 4-5, 6:1-4.

3. De-creation and re-creation

- De-creation: God brings about an inversion of #1 above, usually an escalation of chaos/death/curse.
- Out of that de-creation, God chooses/preserves a remnant/seed and begins a new movement of re-creation through them, often marked by covenants and wordplays on the Hebrew root שבע, “seven/fullness/oath” or “covenant” (ברית).
- Key words found in Genesis 6:5-9:17.

4. Repeat



Genesis 1:1-11:26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

In what ways do you see Yoseph’s story replaying events from the early chapters of Genesis?